

Chapter 32: Reform and Revolt

Kennedy, at 43 was the youngest and only Roman Catholic man elected to presidency. He was also the last president whom it was fun to work with. The Cold War was still active, as Khrushchev spoke out, believing communism would rule the world, and his disbelief in “peaceful coexistence.” The irony was that both leaders wanted to escape the arms race, Khrushchev didn’t quit because he wanted to keep a hold on China, and Kennedy thought a 3rd World War would be the end of civilization. Kennedy saw a possible “world of diversity” in the future, where each separate country would solve its own problems, knowing the differences between nations. Kennedy worked to influence developing nations into democracy, the Peace Corps were part of this. Counterinsurgency was believed to be the way to combat communism, the Green Berets were part of this movement.

Latin America was a new outlet for the CIA. Kennedy now had to deal with the anti-Castro Cubans, armed and trained by the CIA, ready to attack their country. On April 17, 1961 12,000 Cubans landed at the Bay of Pigs. After 3 days the invasion collapsed. The CIA developed “Operation Mongoose” a program to encourage resistance and sabotage in Cuba. Castro continued to incite guerilla action against democratic regimes in Latin America.

Kennedy relied on the Alliance for Progress, which used the US to help other countries. At Punta del Este Latin American states joined the goals of the alliance. Work in Southeast Asia was similar. Henry Cabot Lodge was sent to Saigon as an Ambassador. “Flexible Response” was the newest deviation from Massive Retaliation. It was a form of responding to soviet threats without immediate resort to nuclear weapons. The arms race continued, for neither side would listen. Kennedy asked for more money in the defense budget, and built fallout shelters and advertised about nuclear war.

The Trade Expansion Act of 1962 created authority to negotiate tariff reductions up to 50% for bargaining with a common market. The “Kennedy Round” of negotiations lowered the tariffs around the world.

The missile crisis in Cuba was a problem, as soviets could attack the US long before we could retaliate. The missiles needed to be removed from Cuba. One solution was air strike, another naval blockade, but Kennedy finally chose to cut off all trade with Cuba and demanding destroying the missiles or retaliation would be against the USSR. In June 1963 a “Hot Line” was established between the White House and the Kremlin, as a quick way to keep both governments on the same wavelength. Space was another area where the soviets competed with the US. They had the first man in orbit, we were dedicated to be the first on the moon. On July 20, 1969 Neil A. Armstrong was the first man to walk on the moon.

Kennedy was faced with a 7% unemployment rate, and took on a set of expansionist policies. Inflation was held steady with “wage-price guideposts” keeping wages within the limits of advances in production. The Area Redevelopment Act of 1961 helped poor Americans through a tax reduction.

The Black Revolution was largest in the 1960's. “Freedom riders” defied the Jim Crow laws, and worked toward ending segregation. From MLK rose organizations such as the Congress of Racial Equality (CORE) and the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC). As black discontent grew, so did southern resistance, and they were attacked with cattle prods fire hoses and other things.

On November 22, 1963 Kennedy was shot while riding in an open car in Dallas, Texas. He was honored, as a great president, the first to be admired for helping the poor, the young, and the black. Lyndon Johnson came into presidency after Kennedy’s death, and was the first president with impressive legislative experience. He made solid decisions, and one was the Civil Rights Act of 1964. It prohibited discrimination in use of federal funds and in places of public accommodation and established an Equal Employment Opportunity Commission.

After a US ship reported being attacked off the coast of Vietnam, the war became an American issue, and troops were sent, this met opposition at home and no more of the home front war effort.

Women were in revolt along with the antiwar effort. They, as well as gays and prisoners demanded social acceptance. Most women didn’t agree with the other revolting women, and the first black congresswoman said she was discriminated as a woman more than as a black. Betty Friedman was the first woman to publish a feminist novel, that incited feminist thinking throughout the world, and the National Organization for Women (NOW) was started.

Black Power was new to the world when it surfaced, some blacks didn’t want to integrate, they saw that as submission. Malcolm X was the largest figure of the black power movement. After the black power, a counter-culture arose. People who lived one day at a time, the “hippies” emerged, drugs were prevalent, LSD, Marijuana, and Pep Pills were popular, some of the downfalls was the “ripping off” “trashing” “gang banging” and the amounts of “street people.” The Hell’s Angels emerged at this time, with Charles Manson’s hippie “family.” Court cases involved the counterculture, Gideon v. Wainwright(1963) overruled a decision because a defendant was denied counsel. Escobedo v. Illinois and Miranda v. Arizona reversed criminal convictions because defendants had been denied counsel in trial and interrogation.

The 1968 election saw Johnson trying to get a vote, his chances were demolished as the Tet Offensive failed in Vietnam and intensified the opposition at home. Nixon rose above the crowd to receive a nomination, he won the election, but the democrats controlled both houses of congress. Nixon was going to have a hard time in office.

peaceful coexistence
“world of diversity”

Peace Corps
Green Berets
Bay of Pigs
Alliance for Progress
“Flexible Response”
“Hot Line”
Trade Expansion Act of 1962
“Operation Mongoose”
“Kennedy Round”
Civil Rights Act of 1964
Congress of Racial Equality (CORE); Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC)
National Organization for Women (NOW)
Escobedo v. Illinois; Miranda v. Arizona; Gideon v. Wainwright(1963)
“Hawks” and “Doves”